FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

GIRLS IN SPORT

Periods, changing bodies and staying confident

15

THE QUICK VERSION

> Many teenage girls drop out of sport, and the reasons are often things nobody talks about: periods, body changes, the right sports bra and feeling self-conscious. A few honest, relaxed conversations at home can make the difference between a girl who quits and one who keeps playing for life.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

Puberty brings real changes: periods, breast development, growth spurts and shifting body shape. These can affect comfort, confidence and energy. Girls who feel prepared and supported are much more likely to keep playing. Making these topics normal at home, and not awkward, is one of the most powerful things you can do.

THE FOUR THINGS TO TALK ABOUT

PERIODS

Period pads, tampons, period undies or cups can all work for sport. Pack spares in the kit bag and suggest dark shorts if it helps her feel more confident.

SPORTS BRAS

A well-fitted sports bra makes a big difference to comfort. Get her fitted properly and check again as she grows.

CHANGING BODIES

Hips, weight and shape change in puberty. That's healthy and normal. Avoid comments about weight or body shape.

CONFIDENCE

Feeling self-conscious is common. Ask what would help: different kit, a private changing space, or a friend on the team.

Know the signs that need a doctor

If an active girl's periods are very painful, very heavy, or stop for several months, speak to your GP. Missing periods can be a sign she isn't eating enough for the amount of sport she does, which needs attention.

TRY THIS

1 Make it a normal conversation
Talk about periods and bodies as matter-of-factly as boots and shin pads.

2 Pack a period kit
Spare products, spare undies, pain relief if appropriate, and a small bag.

3 Exercise can help
Gentle movement can ease period cramps for many girls. Let her decide how she feels.

4 Let her lead
Some days she may want to train lighter. Trust her and talk to the coach if needed.

5 Show her role models
Watch women's football together. Seeing strong, confident players matters.

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
"Periods are normal. Let's pack what you need."	~~"You can't play when you have your period."~~
"Let's get you a proper sports bra."	~~"You'll grow out of it, don't worry."~~
"Your body is strong and doing what it should."	~~"You've put on a bit of weight."~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] We've talked openly about periods and sport
- [ ] She has a well-fitted sports bra
- [ ] There's a period kit in her bag
- [ ] I avoid any comments about her weight or shape

Can't tick them all yet? That's normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH'S CORNER

"Nobody talked about periods in sport when many of us were growing up. Girls deserve better. A simple conversation and a packed kit bag can keep a girl in the game for life.

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM